A Restriction Theorem for Springer Fibers

GPT-6 Astra

Communicated and edited by Boming Jia

Abstract

Let G be a connected complex reductive group, $\mathcal{B}$ its flag variety, and $\mathcal{B}_e$ the Springer fiber of a nilpotent element $e \in \operatorname{Lie} G$. Let S be the torus associated with an $\mathfrak{sl}_2$-triple containing e. We prove that the image of the restriction map on complex cohomology $H^*(\mathcal{B}^S) \to H^*(\mathcal{B}_e^S)$ between the S-fixed point loci is the subalgebra of invariants under the component group $A(e)$ of the centralizer of e in G. This proves a conjecture of Hoang, Krylov, and Matvieievskyi. The argument uses global invariant cycles. As an application, we give another proof of the known surjectivity for general linear groups.

1 Introduction

Let G be a connected complex reductive group with Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$ and flag variety $\mathcal{B}$ of Borel subalgebras of $\mathfrak{g}$. Write Ad for the adjoint action of G on $\mathfrak{g}$ and its induced action on $\mathcal{B}$. For $x \in \mathfrak{g}$, let $Z_G(x) = \{g \in G \mid \mathrm{Ad}(g)x = x\}$ be its centralizer in G.

Fix a nilpotent element $e \in \mathfrak{g}$, an $\mathfrak{sl}_2$-triple (e, h, f), and the associated cocharacter $\lambda\colon \mathbb{C}^\times \to G$, with $d\lambda(1) = h$. Set

$$S = \lambda(\mathbb{C}^\times), \qquad A(e) = Z_G(e)/Z_G(e)^\circ,$$

where $Z_G(e)^\circ$ is the identity component of $Z_G(e)$. For $e = 0$, we take the trivial triple and cocharacter. Since $\mathrm{Ad}(\lambda(t))e = t^2 e$, the torus S preserves the Springer fiber

$$\mathcal{B}_e = \{\mathfrak{b} \in \mathcal{B} \mid e \in \mathfrak{b}\}.$$

Throughout the paper, $H^*(X)$ denotes singular cohomology with coefficients in $\mathbb{C}$. For a group H acting on a variety X, write X^H for its fixed point locus. A superscript H on a cohomology group denotes the subspace of H-invariant classes. Let $i\colon \mathcal{B}_e^S \hookrightarrow \mathcal{B}^S$ be the inclusion. The centralizer of the triple acts on $\mathcal{B}_e^S$, and its action on cohomology factors through $A(e)$. We describe this action in Section 2.

The following theorem proves [HKM24, Conjecture 10.10]. Some classical cases were established in [HKM24, Lemma 10.9].

Theorem 1.1. *The pullback map $i^*\colon H^*(\mathcal{B}^S) \to H^*(\mathcal{B}_e^S)$ satisfies*

$$\mathrm{Im}(i^*) = H^*(\mathcal{B}_e^S)^{A(e)}.$$

In particular, i^* is surjective if and only if $A(e)$ acts trivially on $H^*(\mathcal{B}_e^S)$. Since each connected component of $\mathcal{B}^S$ is a flag variety, the invariant algebra is generated in degrees zero and two.

For $G = \mathrm{GL}_n$, the group of invertible $n \times n$ complex matrices with $n \geq 1$, the component group $A(e)$ is trivial, so Theorem 1.1 recovers the known surjectivity of i^* (Corollary 3.5). This also follows from the classical restriction theorem for ordinary Springer fibers [DCP81, Tan82], by equivariant formality and localization. Outside type A, the image of $H^*(\mathcal{B}) \to H^*(\mathcal{B}_e)$ can be a proper subalgebra of $H^*(\mathcal{B}_e)^{A(e)}$ [HKM24, Warning 10.19].

We apply Deligne's global invariant cycle theorem [Del71] to the incidence family of De Concini, Lusztig, and Procesi [DLP88, Sections 2.1–2.4 and 3.7]. The intersections of $\mathcal{B}_e^S$ with the connected components of $\mathcal{B}^S$ also occur in the decomposition of nilpotent Hessenberg cohomology as $A(e)$-modules studied by Precup and Sommers [PS25, Section 3.2 and Corollary 3.6].

At positive admissible slopes, Oblomkov and Yun identify the image of ambient flag cohomology with the invariants under the stabilizer component group and braid-group monodromy for Hessenberg varieties arising from regular semisimple homogeneous affine Springer fibers [OY16, Theorem 5.5.1(1)]. Their proof uses the decomposition theorem and contraction of the incidence family. We apply global invariant cycles over the open orbit $Z_G(h) \cdot e$.

Human Editor's Remark. This paper was generated by GPT-6 Astra and revised together with the Human Editor (HE), Boming Jia. HE has found no mathematical errors in this paper. If any errors are found later, HE will take full responsibility. If the proof is indeed correct, HE does not want any credit for HE's negligible mathematical contribution.

2 Fixed flags and the incidence family

All Springer fibers and fixed point varieties are endowed with their reduced scheme structures.

For a group element or subgroup, $Z_G(-)$ denotes its centralizer under conjugation. For several arguments, it denotes their common centralizer. We write H° for the identity component of an algebraic group H.

Let a complex algebraic group H act on a variety X, and write $m_a \colon X \to X$ for the automorphism induced by $a \in H$. We let a act on cohomology by $m_{a^{-1}}^*$. The complex Lie group $H^\circ(\mathbb{C})$ is path connected. For $a \in H^\circ$, a path from 1 to a induces a homotopy between id_X and m_a. Hence H° acts trivially on $H^*(X)$, and the cohomological action of H factors through H/H°.

For any connected component F of $\mathcal{B}^S$, put $F_e = F \cap \mathcal{B}_e^S$ and write $i_F \colon F_e \hookrightarrow F$ for the inclusion.

Retain the triple (e, h, f) and cocharacter λ from the introduction. For $j \in \mathbb{Z}$, set

$$\mathfrak{g}(j) = \{x \in \mathfrak{g} \mid [h, x] = jx\}, \qquad L = Z_G(S) = Z_G(h), \qquad Z_e = Z_G(e, h, f).$$

Here $Z_G(S)$ consists of the elements of G commuting with every element of S, and $Z_G(e, h, f) = Z_G(e) \cap Z_G(h) \cap Z_G(f)$. The Levi subgroup $L \subset G$ has Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}(0)$ [Hum75]. For $e = 0$, these conventions give $L = Z_e = G$ and $\mathfrak{g}(2) = 0$.

Lemma 2.1. *Let M be a finite-dimensional $\mathfrak{sl}_2$-module and write $M_j = \{v \in M \mid hv = jv\}$ for $j \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then*

$$e(M_0) = M_2, \qquad \ker(e) \cap M_{-2} = 0,$$

and every weight of $\ker(e)$ is nonnegative.

Proof. Decompose M into irreducible modules. On each summand, the kernel of e is the highest-weight line. Moreover, e maps the weight-zero space onto the weight-two space whenever the latter is nonzero. □

Lemma 2.2. *The orbit $L \cdot e$ is open in $\mathfrak{g}(2)$, and the centralizer $Z_L(e)$ of e in L equals Z_e.*

Proof. By Lemma 2.1, the differential at 1 of the orbit map $L \to \mathfrak{g}(2)$, $g \mapsto \mathrm{Ad}(g)e$, is the surjection $\mathfrak{g}(0) \to \mathfrak{g}(2)$, $a \mapsto [a, e]$. Hence $L \cdot e$ is open in $\mathfrak{g}(2)$.

Writing $\mathrm{ad}(e) = [e, -]$, we have, for $g \in Z_L(e)$,

$$\mathrm{Ad}(g)f - f \in \mathfrak{g}(-2) \cap \ker(\mathrm{ad}\, e) = 0.$$

Thus g centralizes the triple, and the reverse inclusion is immediate. □

Proposition 2.3. *The inclusion $Z_e \hookrightarrow Z_G(e)$ induces an isomorphism*

$$Z_e/Z_e^\circ \xrightarrow{\sim} A(e).$$

Proof. Choose a faithful representation $G \hookrightarrow \mathrm{GL}(V)$ on a finite-dimensional complex vector space V, where $\mathrm{GL}(V)$ is its group of linear automorphisms. Identify $\mathfrak{g}$ with its image in the endomorphism algebra $\mathrm{End}(V)$. For $g \in Z_G(e)$, both g and g^{-1} lie in the kernel of $[e, -]$ on $\mathrm{End}(V)$. By Lemma 2.1, their weight decompositions under conjugation by λ have no negative-weight components. Thus the two maps

$$t \longmapsto \lambda(t)g\lambda(t)^{-1}, \qquad t \longmapsto \lambda(t)g^{-1}\lambda(t)^{-1}$$

extend regularly to $t = 0$. The two limiting matrices are inverse to one another and belong to the closed subgroup $G \subset \mathrm{GL}(V)$. Denote the first limit by $r(g)$. Since $Z_G(e)$ is closed and stable under conjugation by $\lambda(t)$, we have $r(g) \in Z_G(e)$. The matrix $r(g)$ has weight zero, so it centralizes S. By Lemma 2.2, we obtain a retraction

$$r\colon Z_G(e) \longrightarrow Z_e, \qquad r(g) = \lim_{t \to 0} \lambda(t)g\lambda(t)^{-1}.$$

The map is algebraic, being the restriction of the weight-zero projection on $\mathrm{End}(V)$, and fixes Z_e pointwise.

The extended map from the affine line $\mathbb{A}^1$ to $Z_G(e)$ takes 1 to g and 0 to $r(g)$, so these elements lie in the same connected component. Thus every connected component of $Z_G(e)$ meets Z_e. Conversely, if $c \in Z_e \cap Z_G(e)^\circ$, then $c = r(c)$ belongs to the connected set $r(Z_G(e)^\circ)$ containing the identity. Hence

$$Z_e \cap Z_G(e)^\circ = Z_e^\circ,$$

proving the assertion. □

The triple centralizer Z_e preserves $\mathcal{B}_e^S$, and its cohomological action factors through $Z_e/Z_e^\circ \simeq A(e)$. This is the action used in Theorem 1.1. The inclusion $\mathcal{B}_e^S \hookrightarrow \mathcal{B}_e$ is Z_e-equivariant, so restriction is compatible with the usual $A(e)$-action on $H^*(\mathcal{B}_e)$.

Lemma 2.4. *Every connected component of $\mathcal{B}^S$ is an orbit of the Levi subgroup L. If B_0 is the Borel subgroup corresponding to $\mathfrak{b}_0 \in \mathcal{B}^S$, then*

$$L \cdot \mathfrak{b}_0 \simeq L/(L \cap B_0),$$

where $L \cap B_0$ is a Borel subgroup of L.

Proof. Fix a maximal torus $T \subset G$ containing S. A Borel subgroup normalized by S contains S, since Borel subgroups are self-normalizing. Conjugacy of maximal tori in L shows that every such subgroup is L-conjugate to a Borel subgroup containing T. There are only finitely many Borel subgroups containing T, so $\mathcal{B}^S$ has finitely many L-orbits. If $T \subset B_0$, then $L \cap B_0$ is the Borel subgroup of L determined by the corresponding positive roots [Hum75]. Each orbit is therefore a projective flag variety. The finitely many orbits are closed and connected, hence are precisely the connected components. □

Fix a connected component $F \subset \mathcal{B}^S$ and a point $\mathfrak{b}_0 \in F$, and let B_0 be the corresponding Borel subgroup. Set $B_L = L \cap B_0$, a Borel subgroup of L. Consider

$$\mathcal{E}_F = \{(x, \mathfrak{b}) \in \mathfrak{g}(2) \times F \mid x \in \mathfrak{b}\}, \qquad \pi_F \colon \mathcal{E}_F \longrightarrow \mathfrak{g}(2), \quad (x, \mathfrak{b}) \longmapsto x.$$

This is the incidence construction of [DLP88, Sections 2.1–2.4 and 3.7].

Proposition 2.5. *The incidence variety $\mathcal{E}_F$ is a vector subbundle of $\mathfrak{g}(2) \times F \to F$, and π_F is projective. Let $\mathcal{O}_F$ denote the trivial line bundle on F, and let $\mathbb{P}_F$ parametrize lines in a vector bundle over F. The projective bundle*

$$\overline{\mathcal{E}}_F = \mathbb{P}_F(\mathcal{E}_F \oplus \mathcal{O}_F),$$

is a smooth projective compactification of $\mathcal{E}_F$. If $F_e \neq \varnothing$, the restriction

$$\pi_F^{-1}(L \cdot e) \longrightarrow L \cdot e$$

is smooth and surjective, and $\pi_F^{-1}(L \cdot e)$ is dense in $\overline{\mathcal{E}}_F$. In particular, F_e is smooth and projective.

Proof. There is an isomorphism over $F = L/B_L$,

$$L \times^{B_L} (\mathfrak{g}(2) \cap \mathfrak{b}_0) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{E}_F, \qquad [g, x] \longmapsto (\mathrm{Ad}(g)x, \mathrm{Ad}(g)\mathfrak{b}_0).$$

Here $(g, x) \sim (gb, \mathrm{Ad}(b^{-1})x)$ for $b \in B_L$. Zariski local sections of $L \to F$ show that this map is an isomorphism. The B_L-equivariant inclusion $\mathfrak{g}(2) \cap \mathfrak{b}_0 \hookrightarrow \mathfrak{g}(2)$ identifies $\mathcal{E}_F$ with a vector subbundle of

$$L \times^{B_L} \mathfrak{g}(2) \simeq \mathfrak{g}(2) \times F, \qquad [g, x] \longmapsto (\mathrm{Ad}(g)x, gB_L).$$

The total space of $\mathcal{E}_F$ is smooth and irreducible. Since $\mathcal{E}_F$ is closed in $\mathfrak{g}(2) \times F$ and F is projective, π_F is projective.

Equivariance implies surjectivity over $L \cdot e$ whenever F_e is nonempty. At a point above $x \in L \cdot e$, the image of the differential of π_F contains the image of the infinitesimal orbit map

$$\mathfrak{g}(0) \longrightarrow \mathfrak{g}(2), \qquad a \longmapsto [a, x].$$

By Lemma 2.2, this map is surjective. Since $\mathcal{E}_F$ and $\mathfrak{g}(2)$ are smooth, π_F is smooth over $L \cdot e$. Its fiber over e is therefore reduced and is identified with F_e by projection to F.

The projective bundle $\overline{\mathcal{E}}_F$ is smooth and projective. It contains $\mathcal{E}_F$ as the open subset where the $\mathcal{O}_F$-coordinate is nonzero. The inverse image of $L \cdot e$ is nonempty and open in the irreducible variety $\mathcal{E}_F$, hence dense in $\overline{\mathcal{E}}_F$. □

3 The restriction theorem

For a complex variety X, let $\pi_0(X)$ be its set of connected components and $\pi_1(X, x)$ its topological fundamental group based at $x \in X$.

Lemma 3.1. *If $F_e \neq \varnothing$, then for every $k \geq 0$, the monodromy representation of $\pi_F^{-1}(L \cdot e) \to L \cdot e$ on $H^k(F_e)$ has the same image as the $A(e)$-action. Thus*

$$H^k(F_e)^{\pi_1(L \cdot e, e)} = H^k(F_e)^{A(e)}.$$

Proof. By Lemma 2.2, the family is the associated bundle

$$L \times^{Z_e} F_e \xrightarrow{\sim} \pi_F^{-1}(L \cdot e), \qquad [g, \mathfrak{b}] \longmapsto (\mathrm{Ad}(g)e, \mathrm{Ad}(g)\mathfrak{b})$$

over L/Z_e, with $(g, \mathfrak{b}) \sim (gc, \mathrm{Ad}(c^{-1})\mathfrak{b})$ for $c \in Z_e$. The analytic principal Z_e-bundle $L \to L/Z_e$ has local sections. A loop based at e lifts to a path in L from 1 to an element $c \in Z_e$. Its transport on cohomology is $m_{c^{-1}}^*$, where $m_c \colon F_e \to F_e$ is the automorphism $\mathfrak{b} \mapsto \mathrm{Ad}(c)\mathfrak{b}$. Two lifts of the same loop starting at 1 have endpoints in the same connected component of Z_e, so they induce the same cohomology operator. Conversely, since the Levi subgroup L is connected, every $c \in Z_e$ can be joined to 1 by a path in L whose projection to L/Z_e is a loop. The monodromy image is therefore the image of $Z_e/Z_e^\circ \simeq A(e)$. □

Theorem 3.2 (Deligne)**.** *Let $p \colon \mathcal{X} \to Y$ be a smooth projective surjective morphism of complex varieties with Y smooth and connected, and let $\overline{\mathcal{X}}$ be a smooth projective compactification of $\mathcal{X}$. For $y \in Y$, write $\mathcal{X}_y = p^{-1}(y)$. Then, for $k \geq 0$,*

$$\mathrm{Im}\big(H^k(\overline{\mathcal{X}}) \longrightarrow H^k(\mathcal{X}_y)\big) = H^k(\mathcal{X}_y)^{\pi_1(Y, y)}.$$

This is [Del71, Théorème 4.1.1(ii)], after extension of scalars from $\mathbb{Q}$ to $\mathbb{C}$. The fibers need not be connected, and p need not extend to $\overline{\mathcal{X}}$.

Proof of Theorem 1.1. Fix $k \geq 0$ and a connected component $F \subset \mathcal{B}^S$ with $F_e \neq \varnothing$. Since the triple centralizer Z_e lies in the connected Levi subgroup L, it acts trivially on $H^*(F)$. Equivariance of i_F implies

$$\mathrm{Im}(i_F^*) \subseteq H^*(F_e)^{A(e)}.$$

Let $\alpha \in H^k(F_e)^{A(e)}$. By Lemma 3.1, it is invariant under the monodromy of the smooth projective family over $L \cdot e$. By Proposition 2.5, $\overline{\mathcal{E}}_F$ is a smooth projective compactification

of $\pi_F^{-1}(L \cdot e)$. Write $j_F \colon F_e \hookrightarrow \overline{\mathcal{E}}_F$ for the embedding $\mathfrak{b} \mapsto (e, \mathfrak{b})$. By Theorem 3.2, there exists $\beta \in H^k(\overline{\mathcal{E}}_F)$ such that $j_F^* \beta = \alpha$.

Let $\sigma_F \colon F \to \mathcal{E}_F \subset \overline{\mathcal{E}}_F$ be the zero section and put $\gamma = \sigma_F^* \beta$. The maps $\sigma_F \circ i_F$ and j_F are homotopic through

$$F_e \times [0,1] \longrightarrow \mathcal{E}_F, \qquad (\mathfrak{b}, t) \longmapsto (te, \mathfrak{b}).$$

This homotopy is well defined because $e \in \mathfrak{b}$ for $\mathfrak{b} \in F_e$. Hence

$$i_F^* \gamma = (\sigma_F \circ i_F)^* \beta = j_F^* \beta = \alpha.$$

We have proved

$$\operatorname{Im}\bigl(i_F^* \colon H^k(F) \longrightarrow H^k(F_e)\bigr) = H^k(F_e)^{A(e)}. \tag{1}$$

If $F_e = \varnothing$, both sides of (1) vanish. Since $Z_e \subset L$, it preserves each F and F_e. Taking the direct sum of (1) over the connected components F of $\mathcal{B}^S$ proves the assertion in every degree. Restriction preserves cup products, so the equality respects the algebra structures. □

The action of Z_e on $\pi_0(\mathcal{B}_e^S)$ factors through $A(e)$, since Z_e° is connected.

Corollary 3.3. *For every connected component F of $\mathcal{B}^S$ with $F_e \neq \varnothing$, the group $A(e)$ acts transitively on the connected components of F_e. In particular, F_e is connected if $A(e)$ is trivial.*

Proof. By (1), we have $H^0(F_e)^{A(e)} = \mathbb{C}$. The left-hand side identifies with the algebra of functions on $\pi_0(F_e)/A(e)$, so this orbit set has one element. □

This transitivity is also proved in [DLP88, Lemma 2.2(iii)].

Corollary 3.4. *The algebra $H^*(\mathcal{B}_e^S)^{A(e)}$ is generated by its degree-zero and degree-two parts. In particular,*

$$H^{2j+1}(\mathcal{B}_e^S)^{A(e)} = 0 \qquad (j \geq 0).$$

Proof. For each connected component F of $\mathcal{B}^S$, choose a Borel subgroup $B_L \subset L$ so that $F \simeq L/B_L$. Let $X^*(B_L)$ be its character group and, for $\chi \in X^*(B_L)$, let $\mathbb{C}_\chi$ be the one-dimensional B_L-module with character χ. Writing Sym for the symmetric algebra over $\mathbb{C}$ and c_1 for the first Chern class, Borel's characteristic homomorphism

$$\operatorname{Sym}\bigl(X^*(B_L) \otimes_{\mathbb{Z}} \mathbb{C}\bigr) \longrightarrow H^*(F), \qquad \chi \longmapsto c_1(L \times^{B_L} \mathbb{C}_\chi),$$

is surjective [Bor53]. The generators $X^*(B_L) \otimes_{\mathbb{Z}} \mathbb{C}$ have degree two. This applies to the connected reductive group L, since a finite central cover induces an isomorphism of flag varieties and an isomorphism of character spaces after tensoring with $\mathbb{C}$. Thus $H^*(\mathcal{B}^S)$ is generated by these Chern classes and the idempotents corresponding to its connected components. Apply Theorem 1.1. □

The stronger vanishing $H^{2j+1}(\mathcal{B}_e^S) = 0$ is proved in [DLP88, Theorem 3.9]. For $e \neq 0$, apply their theorem to $s = \lambda(t)$ with t not a root of unity. The fixed point locus $\mathcal{B}_e^s$ of s then equals $\mathcal{B}_e^S$. The case $e = 0$ is the usual vanishing for $\mathcal{B}$.

Sending a connected component of $\mathcal{B}_e^S$ to the connected component of $\mathcal{B}^S$ containing it induces, by Corollary 3.3, a bijection

$$\pi_0(\mathcal{B}_e^S)/A(e) \xrightarrow{\sim} \{F \in \pi_0(\mathcal{B}^S) \mid F_e \neq \varnothing\}.$$

Corollary 3.5. *If $G = \mathrm{GL}_n$, then the pullback map*

$$i^*\colon H^*(\mathcal{B}^S) \longrightarrow H^*(\mathcal{B}^S_e)$$

is surjective.

Proof. The centralizer $Z_G(e) = Z_G(1+e)$ is connected [SS70, III, 3.22] (see also [Spr76, Section 7.7]). Hence $A(e) = 1$, and the assertion follows from Theorem 1.1. □

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